

Scoop N' Buns: A story of entrepreneurial success, and what you can learn from it.

By Ethan Lin

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Scoop N' Buns, for many local residents of Garland, is more than just a nice ice cream shop. Founded in 2020 by husband-and-wife team Gerardo and Zoya Hernandez, "Mexi-Pino" by heritage, the shop quickly transformed an old thrift store into a place where families and friends gather for creative desserts and rotating flavors. Their sister locations, Cafe Frida and Scoop N' Boba, fuse ice cream favorites with boba creations, extending that same welcoming vibe. From indulgent treats to cozy coffee moments, the Scoop N' Buns family has become a local favorite for sweet escapes and cultural connections in Garland.

But, what could have led to the start of this amazing business? For Zoya, it wasn't an entirely deliberate choice.

Ethan (me): *What caused you to take that initial leap of faith to open your business? I read that you stepped away from nursing to start Scooping Buns.*

Zoya: *Well, um, well, 2020 was COVID, right? So even before that, I took a break from my job just because my mom got a stroke. It's not something that, "Oh, you know what? I want to be an entrepreneur." (0:51) It's actually from, you know, because my mom, so I had to take time off from nursing to take care of my mom personally. (0:59) She had a stroke and we had to, you know, everything went so fast that we had, we didn't have a choice, but to put her in hospice. The nurses were being, I don't know what, what the word for it, but it's almost like we were being bullied to do something that it's not ethically like legal. And I'm like, I can't do this, you know? Um, so, you know, they cut my hours and I'm like, I was literally grieving. I paid all my savings from my mom's funeral. Like I can't do, you know, full time to part time forcibly. It was just not feasible.*

Ethan:

So you needed some flexibility.

Zoya:

Exactly. So yeah, I told Gerardo, I was like, you know what, I can't do this. I have to find something else. And so, but yeah, I mean, long story short, I've had some surgeries and all that stuff. And I'm like, I don't know what to do. But I've always wanted to be a baker. I've always wanted, actually, I was baking whenever my mom was sick. So that was kind of like my, so that's kind of like how it started. Do you know how we have tres leches here?

Ethan:

Yeah.

Zoya:

So that's when it started. Actually, I started making a recipe for the tres leches to help gain money for my mom's hospital bills. So I took off from that. So in the midst of taking care of my mom, I started selling tres leches cakes. So I started trying to sell cakes, cookies and all that stuff, because that's literally what I know. So just baking. So that helped out, you know, the bills from hospital bills all the way to like, you know, so.

Gerardo also has a lawn business for probably about five, six, seven years operating before we met and whatnot. So he had experience in entrepreneurship and all that stuff. We decided that since we both needed some kind of like, what is it called? Like a change, right? And so we decided, what about an ice cream shop in Garland?

So that's why we decided, we're like, okay, what about a restaurant? Like a little bakery first. And then Gerardo was like, you know what? Yeah. I mean, you know how to bake and we love ice cream. So we kind of got that idea and yeah, we did a lot of research. I had fun doing a lot of research. We looked at all the buildings. You have to do research first. A lot of research actually. And yeah, we found this, it was very, very dingy, but we thought it had some, I mean, me and Gerardo had like creative minds as well. They were like, you know what? I think we can see something from here. And so, yeah, that's, that's where it started.

It's important to note what Zoya and Gerardo did, by filling in that missing bakery space. When a business or organization identifies what others have overlooked, whether it's a new product, a better service, or a more inclusive approach, they can establish a sustainable competitive advantage and improve market positioning. Having a better position to make sales increases profits. The couple continued to expand their business to Scoop and Boba following the success of their first endeavor.

However, 2023 was a breaking point for the couple. When starting a business, it is important to recognize the risks of your industry. For an Ice Cream shop like Scoop N' Buns and Scoop N' Boba, the business was very cyclical, with business peaking in the summer and dipping in the winter. At the time, having a small amount of menu items aggravated the problem. And with the model of their business, they could not easily exit or expand their position in the market, due to its basis being a casual Ice Cream Shop. So, what did they do?

Zoya: *There were definitely a lot of challenges and almost actually 2023 was our breaking point. So much so that we wondered, "are we going to close or not?" Just because we're an ice cream shop solely. It's a dessert. It's a very seasonal business. So we decided to sell a lot of stuff, AKA Gerardo's lawn trucks, Gerardo's, like all this stuff. We took some of our savings. It pretty much*

was a hail Mary on us in 2023, honestly. And we didn't tell anybody, you know, cause I don't know. We didn't want to be a burden to the community, but at the same time, we wanted to be a part of the community. So we took that turn and I'm like, you know what? We even, I think, borrowed money from people that were like, I really don't, we're not the type of people that borrow money, but we had to like to borrow from my sister, you know, brother-in-law and you know, mostly like Gerardo's like equipment stuff. And he was like, no, I can do this. But I'm like, I feel so bad. He sold his favorite truck and I'm like, okay. So with that money, we took a chance to, um, open Cafe Frida in 2023.

What else contributed to Cafe Frida's success? Within Downtown Garland, the businesses are quite prominent, becoming very well renowned and reputable. How did they get to this point, besides good ice cream? The owners talk about their role in the community quite a bit, attributing their role to putting themselves out there through community involvement.

Zoya: *You know, it's not going to be handed to you unless, I don't know what young folks do these days, the Tik Tok and all that stuff. But with us, it was definitely really hard to get our branding out there. Um, but what we did was to reach out to community fundraisers with Garland High School, fundraisers with this, fundraisers with everybody, um, try to give out free stuff to everyone. So that's, that's what, what we did as far as to be a part of the community, just being out there. Um, and I think that's what makes us different than any other establishments out there.*

The owners talk about the role of organization within a business. Not only does it contribute to the customer experience, but it also streamlines productivity and makes labor easier.

Zoya: *Well, I would say definitely if you're in a business world or anything that you want to, any profession out there, you need to have a solid work ethic. That means you need to be organized. You need to be, I would say like you need to be organized and clean, actually like organized and clean. I think if you're a business owner, you really have to be organized and do a lot of research for sure.*

It's not going to be easy. You have to be mindful of the back expenses, plumbing, electricity, people stealing from you, you know, like all this stuff is like something that the world does not teach you, but you have to figure it out first. So yeah, I would say just being organized can get you further than what you have. Like if you're organized here, I think you're going to have a better chance of being successful.

Like I always tell my employees, when you're doing a coffee, you need to be able to have your milk over here, your syrups over here. If you don't have that, this happens: "Oh, I gotta get this,

oh, I gotta get this,” so like it makes your surroundings chaotic. If you're organized, wherever you're pursuing or whatever degree you're having, you're going to have a better chance.

Organized is such a simple word, but once you have organization, like all this, you have to organize where everything is at. If it's not organized, we do not have this. We do not have employees. We have recipes, we have instructions, we have everything for the young kids to follow. If we do not have that, then we do not have any 25 employees. So that is literally one of the important things. If you want to do a business, you have to be organized, everything.

Obviously business equals expanding. If you want to expand, then you have to have your employees. If you want to have your employees, what do you want them to do? Follow what you want them to do. So it really roots to that.

Be organized in your life first, especially if you're doing entrepreneurship or being in healthcare, like something that you're trying to give in the community or serving people, you really have to be organized or else your business will fail. I hate to say that, or else businesses will always fail. It all roots to that organization. It all roots to the management, right?

Business practices aside, the owners emphasize that a business's true impact extends beyond its products. Zoya and Gerardo believe that character, authenticity, and interpersonal connection are central to the customer experience. This philosophy aligns with experiential branding, where value is created not only through what is sold, but through how customers feel when they engage with the brand. By fostering a welcoming environment and building genuine relationships with patrons, they ensure that every visit becomes a memorable interaction.

***Zoya:** Actually a huge part of it. Being a Filipino, my mom always told me that being a Filipino and a nurse myself and my mom as a nurse. So I was so, I was already, what's the name for that? I was already exposed to what hospitality looks like for Filipinos and especially becoming a nurse. It's such a huge part of us. So the way we operate our business is that number one is always hospitality. So always, always, you know, connect with your people, connect with your community. It's always like that, especially with me, my employees and all that stuff. I'll always like to tell them, you know, like the hospitality, always welcome people and, you know, just be kind.*

Scoop N' Buns stands as a testament to what determination, community engagement, and strategic adaptability can accomplish. From navigating personal hardship to identifying a gap in the Garland market, Zoya and Gerardo built more than a business. They built a space where culture, comfort, and creativity intersect. Their willingness to take calculated risks, diversify offerings to combat seasonality, and participate actively in local events demonstrates a sophisticated understanding of market positioning and brand visibility.

Most importantly, their story reveals that success is rooted in people. Organization ensures operational stability. Hospitality ensures that customers feel valued. Community involvement strengthens brand reputation and embeds the business into the social fabric of the city. In short, Scoop N' Buns succeeds by doing more than serving ice cream. It brings people together.